

LEAP Civics Classroom Assessment Items

Purpose and Use

The LEAP Social Studies Classroom Assessment Items are intended for use in classroom instruction and assessment, meaning that educators may choose to incorporate the sources and items into daily lessons or classroom tests to complement their instructional and assessment materials. The Social Studies Classroom Assessment Items offer examples of how social studies knowledge and skills may be assessed in alignment with the 2022 Louisiana Student Standards for Social Studies (LS4) and provide students and teachers an opportunity to engage with the different sources and item types they may interact with on the LEAP 2025 Civics Assessment.

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Item Set: The Constitutional Convention

Read and study the sources about key compromises of the Constitutional Convention. Then use the sources to answer the questions.

Source 1

Adapted from the Virginia Plan (1787)

This excerpt includes resolutions from the Virginia Plan, drafted by James Madison and proposed by the Virginia delegates to the Constitutional Convention in 1787. In response, William Paterson proposed the New Jersey Plan.

Resolved

1. That it is the opinion of this committee that a national government ought to be established consisting of a supreme legislative, judiciary, and executive. . . .
3. That the members of the first branch of the national legislature ought to be elected by the people of the several states for the term of three years.
4. That the members of the second branch of the national legislature ought to be chosen by the individual legislatures. . . .
7. That the right of suffrage in the first branch of the national legislature should be according to some equitable ratio of representation — namely, in proportion to the whole number of white and other free citizens.
8. That the right of suffrage in the second branch of the national legislature ought to be according to the rule established for the first.
9. That a national Executive be instituted to consist of a single person. This person is to be chosen by the national legislature with power to carry into execution the national laws.

Source 2

Voting Record on the Virginia Plan and Connecticut Compromise (1787)

This table shows how each state voted on the Virginia Plan and Connecticut Compromise (Great Compromise), along with each state's population according to the 1790 census. States that chose not to vote are marked with a dash.

State	Population	Vote on Virginia Plan	Vote on Connecticut Compromise
Virginia	747,550 	yes	no
Pennsylvania	433,611 	yes	no
North Carolina	395,005 	yes	yes
Massachusetts	378,556 	yes	—
New York	340,241 	no	—
Maryland	319,728 	—	yes
South Carolina	249,073 	yes	no
Connecticut	237,655 	yes	yes
New Jersey	184,139 	no	yes
New Hampshire	141,899 	—	—
Georgia	82,548 	yes	no
Rhode Island	69,112 	—	—
Delaware	59,096 	no	yes

Source 3

Adapted from Federalist Paper Number 54 (1788)

by James Madison

This excerpt from Federalist Paper Number 54 discusses how to count enslaved people in the census for the purposes of apportionment.

In every state, a certain proportion of inhabitants are deprived of their rights by the constitution of the state. These people will be included in the census that the federal constitution uses to apportion the representatives. The southern states might respond to this situation by insisting that slaves, as inhabitants, should have been admitted into the census according to their full number. That would be in like manner with other inhabitants. However, these states are willing to waive part of their position. All that they ask is that compromise be made by both sides of the debate. Let the case of the slaves be considered a unique one. Let a compromise be adopted, which regards them as inhabitants, but below the equal level of free inhabitants.

Source 4

Adapted from Federalist Number 68 (1788)

by Alexander Hamilton

In this excerpt, Hamilton discusses the process for selecting the president of the United States.

According to the plan developed at the Constitutional Convention, the people of each state will choose a number of persons as electors. These electors will meet within the state and vote for the person they think is most fit to be president. Their votes will be handed over to the seat of the national government, and the person who has a majority of the votes will become the president. . . .

The process of election helps ensure that the office of president will never fall to any person who is not well qualified. Talents for manipulation and popularity alone may be sufficient to elevate a man to the top position in a single state. But it will require other talents to establish him in the confidence of the whole Union to make him a successful candidate for the distinguished office of president of the United States.

1. Use **Source 1** to answer the question.

Part A

Which statement **best** explains how the Virginia Plan would affect the structure of the new government?

- A. It would require two-year term limits for elected and appointed officials.
- B. It would establish two branches of government for a balanced distribution of power.
- C. It would create a bicameral legislature with proportional representation in the lower chamber.
- D. It would include a dual chief executive with separate roles and responsibilities.

Part B

Which statement **best** explains how the New Jersey Plan differed from the Virginia Plan?

- A. The New Jersey Plan placed all power with a single branch of government.
- B. The New Jersey Plan proposed a unicameral legislature with equal representation.
- C. The New Jersey Plan placed all power with states instead of the federal government.
- D. The New Jersey Plan proposed that the Supreme Court decide qualifications for representation.

2. Use **Source 2** to answer the question.

Which statement **best** explains why the four most populous states supported the Virginia Plan?

- A. They wanted representation based on population.
- B. They wanted each person in the population to have a direct vote on every issue.
- C. They wanted the same representation regardless of population.
- D. They wanted every person counted in the population despite their social status.

3. Use **Source 3** to answer the question.

Which phrase from Source 3 **best** explains how delegates at the Constitutional Convention agreed to resolve the representation of enslaved people?

- A. "a certain proportion of inhabitants are deprived of their rights"
- B. "included in the census that the federal constitution uses to apportion the representatives"
- C. "should have been admitted into the census according to their full number"
- D. "regards them as inhabitants, but below the equal level of free inhabitants"

4. Use **Source 4** to answer the question.

Which statements **best** describe the Electoral College established at the Constitutional Convention?

Select the **two** correct answers.

- A. It makes sure that the president is elected by the popular vote.
- B. It attempts to ensure that a well-qualified individual is elected president.
- C. It guarantees each state has the same number of votes for president.
- D. It gives the upper chamber the power to appoint the president.
- E. It allows each state to independently decide who to support for president.

5. Use **the sources** to answer the question.

Write in the chart the correct compromise and resolution for each issue debated at the Constitutional Convention.

Issue	Compromise	Resolution
How to represent states in Congress		
How to count the population for representation and taxation		
How to elect the president		

Compromise Answer Choices:

Commerce Compromise
Electoral College
Great Compromise
Three-Fifths Compromise

Resolution Answer Choices:

Establish a system in which a select group of state officials vote for candidates.

Allow states to partially count enslaved people in the total population.

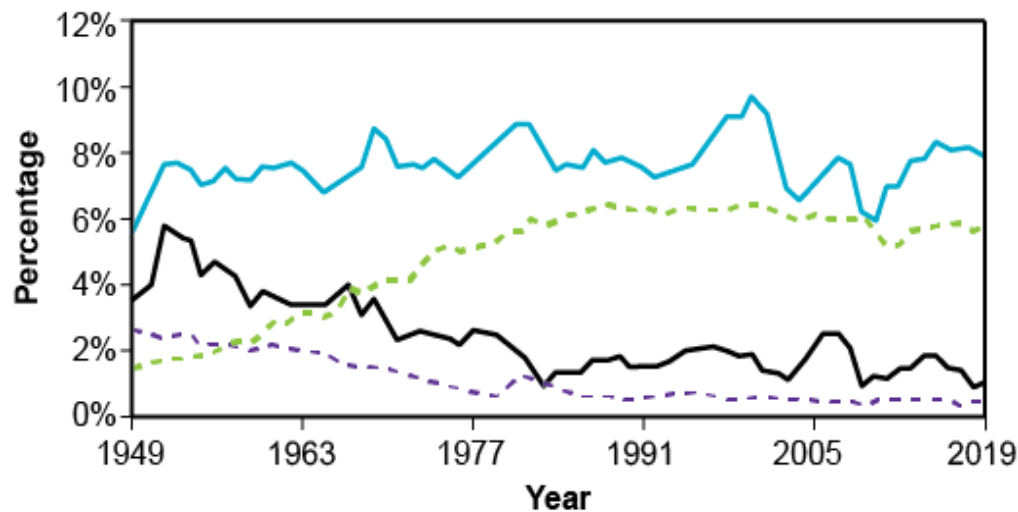
Establish a two-chamber structure with one apportioned by population and one equally apportioned.

Allow for tariffs on imports to the United States.

Standalone Items

7. Use **the graph** to answer the question.

Sources of Federal Revenue as a Percentage of GDP, 1949 – 2019



Key	
	corporate income tax
	individual income tax
	excise tax
	social insurance (payroll) tax

Which forms of taxation have **most likely** decreased between 1949 and 2019 according to the graph?

Select the **two** correct answers.

- A. taxes on the profits of private companies
- B. taxes on retirement investments by people
- C. taxes on luxury goods bought by consumers
- D. taxes on the property values of a home
- E. taxes on the incomes of a private citizens

8. Use **the excerpt** to answer the question.

Adapted from the Oath of Allegiance

I hereby declare, on oath, that I absolutely give up all allegiance and devotion to any foreign prince, leader, state, or sovereignty, of whom or which I have ever before been a subject or citizen. I will support and defend the Constitution and laws of the United States of America against all enemies, foreign and domestic. . . . I will bear arms on behalf of the United States when required by the law. . . . I will perform work of national importance under civilian direction when required by the law. . . .

Part A

Which phrase **best** explains the purpose of the Oath of Allegiance?

- A. to have new citizens pledge their loyalty to the United States
- B. to offer new citizens an opportunity to learn about U.S. culture
- C. to allow new citizens a chance to be employed by the government
- D. to ensure new citizens uphold their promise to help foreign nations

Part B

Which phrase **best** describes a way new citizens can fulfill the purpose in Part A?

- A. by voting in local and state elections
- B. by working in industries with high demand
- C. by serving in the military if needed
- D. by showing support for the current president

9. Write in the chart the correct type of primary election for each description.

Type of Primary Election	Description
	allows voters to meet, discuss issues, and coordinate support
	allows only voters registered for a specific party to participate
	allows voters of any party to participate

Answer Choices:

open

closed

caucus

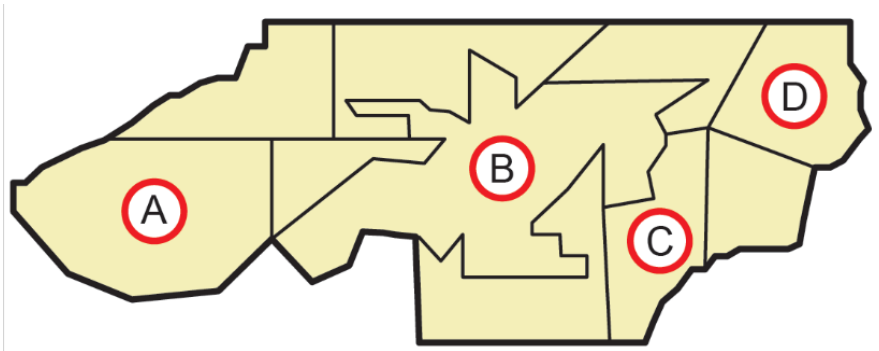
blanket

10. Answer **both parts** of the question.

Part A

The map shows the congressional districts for an imaginary state.

Fill in the circle of the district that is **most likely** gerrymandered.

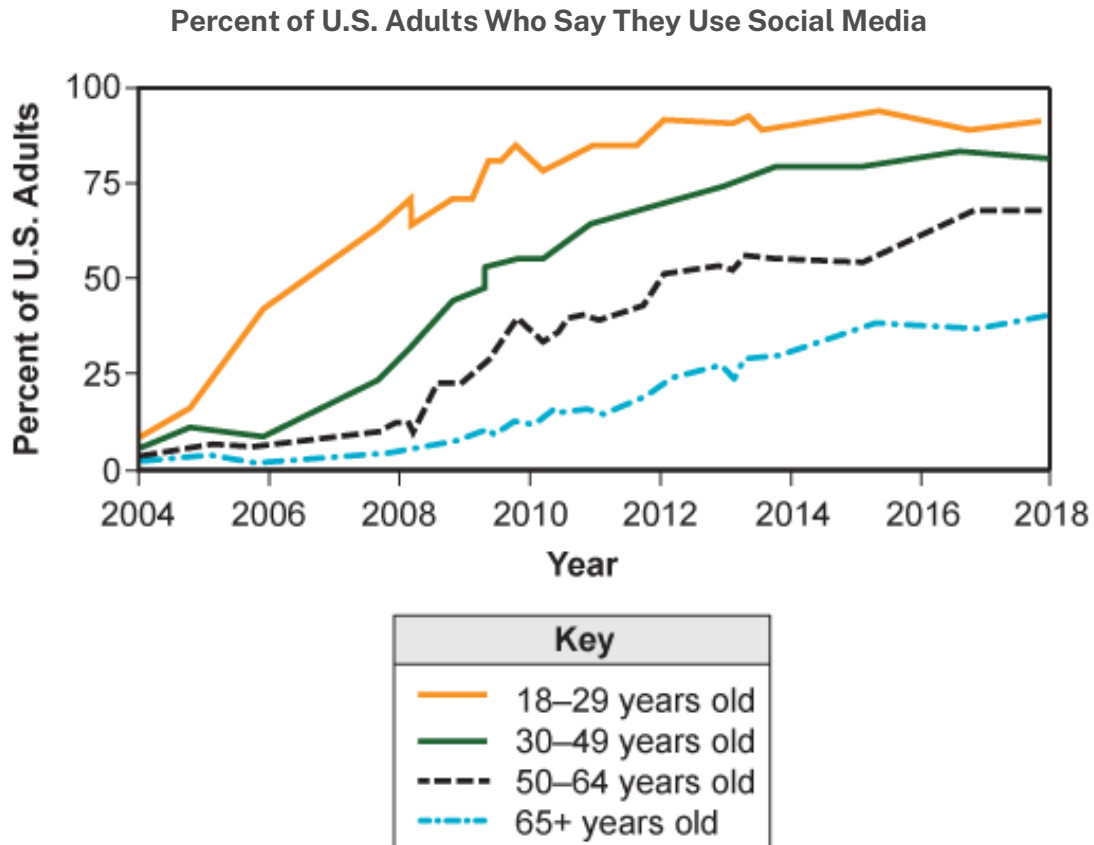


Part B

Which phrase explains why gerrymandering **most likely** occurs in some congressional districts?

- A. to make sure candidates have similar demographic traits to the population in the district
- B. to make congressional elections more competitive between the two parties in the district
- C. to create an electoral advantage for one of the parties or candidates in the district
- D. to account for estimated future population growth in the district

11. Use **the graph** to answer the question.



Which statement **best** explains how the trend shown in the graph affected political campaigns?

- A. Campaigns increased social media use because they wanted to attract elderly voters.
- B. Campaigns decreased spending on television ads because of the growing popularity of social media.
- C. Campaigns increased social media use because voter turnout by younger people is usually high.
- D. Campaigns decreased spending on online ads because of rising costs to advertise on social media.

Task: Foundations, Structures, and Systems of U.S. Government

Read and study the sources about the foundations, systems, and structures of the U.S. government. Use the sources to answer the questions. As you study the sources and answer the questions, get ready to write about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States.

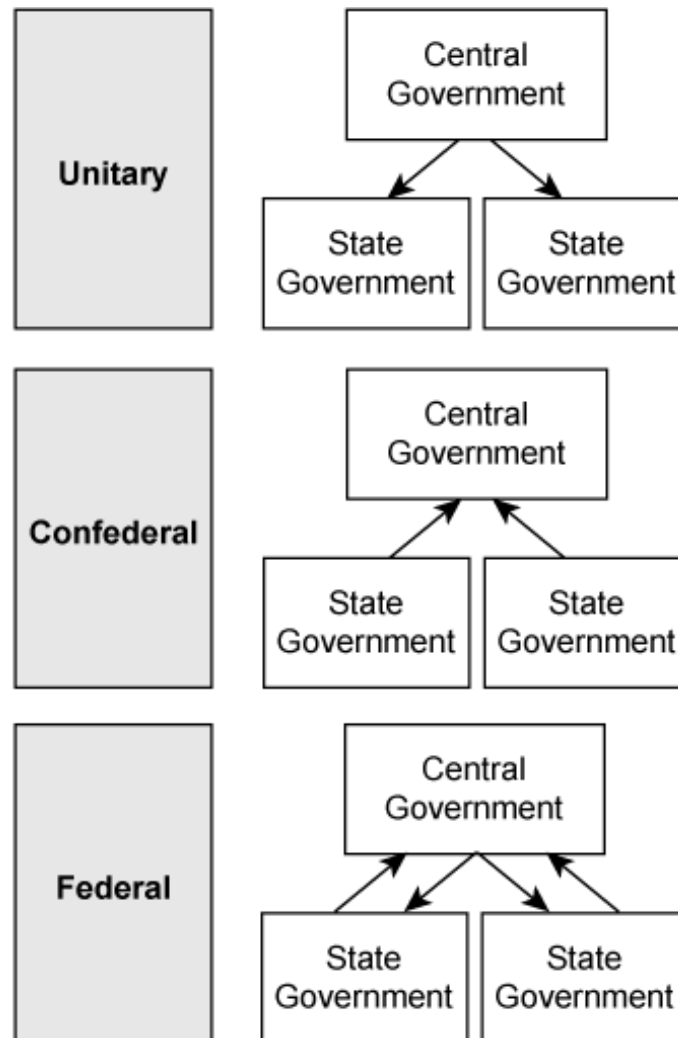
Source 1

Systems and Structures of Government

Characteristic	System or Structure	
Who can participate in the government?	democracy	direct democracy
		representative democracy (republic)
	autocracy	monarchy
		totalitarianism and dictatorship
What is the relationship between the legislative branch and the executive branch?	presidential	
	parliamentary	
What is the legislative structure?	unicameral	
	bicameral	

Source 2

Distribution of Power in Three Systems of Government



Source 3

Adapted from *Common Sense* (1776)

by Thomas Paine

In this excerpt from Common Sense, Thomas Paine discusses monarchy as a system of government.

In the early ages of the world, according to scripture, there were no kings. The consequence of this was that there were no wars. It is the pride of the kings which throw mankind into confusion and war. Holland without a king has enjoyed more peace for this last century than any of the monarchical governments in Europe. The exalting of one man so greatly above the rest cannot be justified on the equal rights of nature.

To the evil of monarchy, we have added that of the right of the children of the present monarch to assume the throne. All men being originally equals, no one by birth should have a right to set up his own family as rulers forever.

But it is not so much the absurdity of this system which concerns us as the evil of it. Rather than ensuring that good and wise men have assumed the throne, it has opened a door for the foolish, wicked, and improper to become rulers and oppressors. Men who view themselves as born to reign and view others to obey soon become insolent. Selected from the rest of mankind, their minds are early poisoned by their own sense of importance. The world they act in differs so materially from the world at large that they have but little opportunity of understanding the real world. When they become rulers of the government, they are frequently the most ignorant and unfit of any throughout the land.

Source 4

Adapted from Federalist Number 10 (1787)

by James Madison

In this excerpt from Federalist Number 10, Madison compares a pure democracy with a republic.

It may be concluded that a pure democracy consisting of a small number of citizens, who assemble and administer the government in person, would not be able to avoid the mischiefs of faction. A common passion or interest will, in almost every case, be felt by a majority of people. And there is nothing to check the temptation to sacrifice the weaker party or the individual who disagrees with the majority. Hence, such democracies have ever been scenes of chaos and contention. They have been incompatible with personal security or the rights of property. They have in general been as short in their lives as they have been violent in their deaths.

A republic, a government in which representation takes place on behalf of the people, opens a different prospect, and it promises the cure that we are seeking.

There are two great points of difference between a direct democracy and a republic. First, in a republic, the delegation of the government belongs to a small number of citizens elected by the rest. Secondly, a republic extends to a greater number of citizens and a greater sphere of the country.

The effect is to refine and enlarge the public view by passing it through the medium of a chosen body of citizens whose wisdom may best discern the true interest of their country. Under such a regulation, the public voice pronounced by the representatives of the people may be more consistent with the public good than if pronounced by the people themselves.

12. Use **Source 1** to answer the question.

Which statements **best** describe the government of the United States?

Select the **two** correct answers.

- A. Government is ruled directly by the people.
- B. Laws are made by a bicameral legislature.
- C. State courts can declare a national law unconstitutional.
- D. The president appoints the legislature.
- E. Elected officials represent the interests of their constituents.

13. Use **Source 1** to answer the question.

Select the system that **most closely** relates to each characteristic in the chart to compare the presidential system and parliamentary system. Select **one** answer for **each** characteristic.

Characteristic	Presidential System	Parliamentary System	Both Systems
A prime minister is selected by the legislature and serves as head of government	☐	☐	☐
Separation of powers exists between the executive and legislative branches	☐	☐	☐
Members of the legislature are elected directly by people	☐	☐	☐
Separate elections are held for the legislature and executive	☐	☐	☐

14. Use **Source 2** to answer the question.

Write in the chart **one** correct description for **each** system of government to compare the unitary, confederate, and federal systems.

System	Description
Unitary	
Confederal	
Federal	

Descriptions:

Power is centralized in a single national government.

Powers are divided equally among states in the absence of a national government.

Powers of national government are supreme, but powers are also reserved to state governments.

Power is concentrated in independent states, but powers are also given to the national government.

15. Use **Source 3** to answer the questions.

Part A

Which statement **best** describes the viewpoint about monarchy expressed by Thomas Paine in Source 3?

- A. Monarchy selects leaders based on their ability to govern large territories.
- B. Monarchy represents the interests of the people it rules.
- C. Monarchy reduces the loyalty of citizens to their government.
- D. Monarchy leads to poor decisions being made by leaders.

Part B

Which evidence from Source 3 **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “In the early ages of the world, according to scripture, there were no kings.”
- B. “The exalting of one man so greatly above the rest cannot be justified on the equal rights of nature.”
- C. “All men being originally equals, no one by birth should have a right to set up his own family as rulers forever.”
- D. “When they become rulers of the government, they are frequently the most ignorant and unfit of any throughout the land.”

16. Use **Source 4** to answer the question.

Which statement **most** accurately describes the claim made by James Madison in Source 4 about the best form of government?

- A. Direct democracy is best because elected officials will vote for what the majority wants.
- B. Direct democracy is best because it can unite a country with a large population.
- C. A republic is best because elected officials can make laws for the common good.
- D. A republic is best because it allows citizens to vote directly on laws.

Answer Key and Rubrics

Group	Number	Type	Key			Points	Alignment										
Item Set: The Constitutional Convention	1	TPI	Part A: C Part B: B See Scoring Guidance			2	Content: C.8e S&P: C.1										
	2	MC	A			1	Content: C.8e S&P: C.5										
	3	MC	D			1	Content: C.8e S&P: C.6b										
	4	MS	B, E			1	Content: C.11f										
	5	TE	<table><tr><th>Issue</th><th>Compromise</th><th>Resolution</th></tr><tr><td>How to represent states in Congress</td><td>Great Compromise</td><td>establish a two-chamber structure with one apportioned by population and one equally apportioned</td></tr><tr><td>How to count the population for representation and taxation</td><td>Three-Fifths Compromise</td><td>allow states to partially count enslaved people in the total population</td></tr><tr><td>How to elect the president</td><td>Electoral College</td><td>establish a system in which a select group of state officials vote for candidates</td></tr></table> Scoring Rules Full (3 pts): 6 of 6 correct responses Full (2 pts): 4 or 5 of 6 correct responses Partial (1 pt): 3 of 6 correct responses None (0 pts): 0–2 of 6 correct responses	Issue	Compromise	Resolution	How to represent states in Congress	Great Compromise	establish a two-chamber structure with one apportioned by population and one equally apportioned	How to count the population for representation and taxation	Three-Fifths Compromise	allow states to partially count enslaved people in the total population	How to elect the president	Electoral College	establish a system in which a select group of state officials vote for candidates	3	Content: C.8e S&P: C.3
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How to elect the president	Electoral College	establish a system in which a select group of state officials vote for candidates															
6	CR	See rubric .			4	Content: C.8e S&P: C.4											
Standalone Items	7	MS	A, C			1	Content: C.9h S&P: C.6a										
	8	TPD	Part A: A Part B: C See Scoring Guidance .			2	Content: C.11b S&P: C.6a										

Group	Number	Type	Key				Points	Alignment	
	9	TE	Type of Primary Election		Description		2	Content: C.11e S&P: C.4	
			caucus		allows voters to meet, discuss issues, and coordinate support				
			closed		allows only voters registered for a specific party to participate				
			open		allows voters of any party to participate				
			Scoring Rules Full (2 pts): 3 of 3 correct responses Partial (1 pt): 2 of 3 correct responses None (0 pts): 0 or 1 of 3 correct responses						
	10	TPI	Part A: Circle Labeled B Part B: C				2	Content: C.11g S&P: C.4	
	11	MC	B				1	Content: C.11h S&P: C.6a	
Task: Foundations, Structures, and Systems of U.S. Government	12	MS	B, E				1	Content: C.9	
	11	TE	Characteristic		Presidential System	Parliamentary System	Both Systems	2	Content: C.8b S&P: C.6a
			A prime minister is selected by the legislature and serves as head of government			X			
Separation of powers exists between the executive and legislative branches			X						
Members of the legislature are elected directly by people					X				
			Separate elections are held for the legislature and executive			X			
			Scoring Rules Full (2 pts): 4 of 4 correct answers selected Partial (1 pts): 2 or 3 of 4 correct answers selected None (0 pts): 0 or 1 of 4 correct answers selected						

Group	Number	Type	Key	Points	Alignment								
	12	TE	<table><tr><th>System</th><th>Description</th></tr><tr><td>Unitary</td><td>Power is centralized in a single national government.</td></tr><tr><td>Confederal</td><td>Power is concentrated in independent states, but powers are also given to the national government.</td></tr><tr><td>Federal</td><td>Powers of national government are supreme, but powers are also reserved to state governments.</td></tr></table> Scoring Rules Full (2 pts): 3 of 3 correct responses Partial (1 pts): 2 of 3 correct responses None (0 pts): 0 or 1 of 3 correct responses	System	Description	Unitary	Power is centralized in a single national government.	Confederal	Power is concentrated in independent states, but powers are also given to the national government.	Federal	Powers of national government are supreme, but powers are also reserved to state governments.		
System	Description												
Unitary	Power is centralized in a single national government.												
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	12	TPD	Part A: D Part B: D See Scoring Guidance .	2	Content: C.8a, C.8d S&P: C.6b								
	13	MC	C	1	Content: C.8b, C.8d S&P: C.6b								
	14	ER	See rubric .	4	Content: C.9, C.8g S&P: C.7a								

Constructed Response Rubric

Score	Scoring Description
4	Student correctly explains one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention and explains how a specific compromise addressed that issue.
3	Student correctly identifies one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention, without explaining it, and correctly explains how a specific compromise addressed that issue. OR Student correctly explains one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention and correctly identifies how a specific compromise addressed that issue, without explaining it.
2	Student correctly identifies one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention and correctly identifies how a specific compromise addressed that issue, without explaining either. OR Student correctly explains one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention. OR Student correctly explains one specific compromise from the Constitutional Convention, without connecting it to a debated issue.
1	Student correctly identifies one issue debated at the Constitutional Convention or correctly identifies one specific compromise from the Constitutional Convention, without explaining it. OR The response includes correct information related to the prompt that demonstrates some student content knowledge about issues and compromises debated at the Constitutional Convention.
0	The response contained only incorrect or irrelevant information or the item was left blank.

Note: Responses are not penalized for any errors in spelling, punctuation, grammar, or capitalization.

Sample Response: One issue debated at the Constitutional Convention was how states were going to be represented in the new government. There were two plans proposed. The Virginia Plan was to have states represented based on population, and the New Jersey Plan was to have all states get an equal number of representatives in a one-house legislature. A compromise was made, called the Connecticut Compromise, and it stated that there would be two houses in the Legislative Branch. One house would have an equal number of representatives per state, and in the other house, a state's number of representatives would be based on that state's population.

Extended Response Rubric

Score	Scoring Description
4	Response includes a correct claim about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States. Response includes a correct explanation that addresses the prompt and includes at least one reference to a given source and relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given source.
3	Response includes a correct claim about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States. Response includes a correct explanation that addresses the prompt and includes at least one reference to a given source or relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given sources, but not both. OR Response includes a correct claim about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States. Response includes at least one reference to a given source and relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given source, but does not explain the evidence. OR Response includes a correct explanation to address the systems or structures of U.S. government and how they reflect the fundamental principles of the United States. The explanation includes at least one reference to a given source and relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given source
2	Response includes a correct claim about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States with at least one reference to a given source or relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given source. OR Response includes a correct explanation to address the systems or structures of U.S. government and how they reflect the fundamental principles of the United States. The explanation includes at least one reference to a given source or relevant content knowledge that is not directly provided in the given source.
1	Response includes a correct claim about how the systems or structures of the U.S. government show the fundamental principles of the United States. OR Response includes correct information that is not directly relevant to the prompt but that demonstrates some student content knowledge about systems, structures, or fundamental principles of the United States government.
0	Response does not include any elements described above.

Note: Responses are not penalized for any errors in spelling, punctuation, grammar, or capitalization.

Sample Response: The systems and structures of the United States government reflect its fundamental principle of representative democracy. When the United States government was created, the Founding Fathers structured the government in a way to ensure that the people elected their representatives in government to make decisions on behalf of large populations of people. In Source 3 Thomas Paine says that a government where one person holds all of the power is corrupt and evil. In Source 4, James Madison states that a government where people vote for their representatives is more consistent with the public good than a direct democracy because it extends to a greater number of citizens.

Scoring Guidance

Item Type	Scoring Rules
Two-Part Independent (TPI)	• Full credit (2 pts): Both Part A and Part B have correct answers • Partial credit (1 pt): Either Part A or Part B have correct answers • No credit (0 pts): Neither Part A nor Part B have correct answers
Two-Part Dependent (TPD)	• Full credit (2 pts): Both Part A and Part B have correct answers • Partial credit (1 pt): Part A has a correct answer, but Part B has an incorrect answer • No credit (0 pts): Part A has an incorrect answer, and Part B has a correct answer OR neither Part A nor Part B has a correct answer